



Innovation and knowledge sharing across professional boundaries: Political interplay between boundary objects and brokers

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Boundary objects
Brokers
Interplay
Innovation
Knowledge sharing

ABSTRACT

The article examines the process of innovation and knowledge sharing from a perspective that focuses on the influence that local circumstances can have. In particular, it looks at the problems of knowledge sharing between groups of professionals. It presents a comparative analysis of two studies, one involving two groups of IT professionals; the other a network of healthcare professionals. The data was collected in two sets. The first set consisted of the results from two earlier, independent studies; the second was collected specifically for this article. We investigate the role played by boundary objects and brokers. Through an analysis of the interplay between boundary object and broker, we uncover the dynamics of the innovation process and show that the role played by the broker can be political. We identify two strategies that are used by brokers in the selection of a boundary object. The first is directed towards achieving a balance between the actors involved and the second is directed towards controlling their activities. We conclude by suggesting that other researchers should also consider the interplay between broker and boundary object when examining cross-boundary knowledge sharing.

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1. Introduction

It is now received wisdom that innovation stems from collaboration and knowledge sharing across professional or organizational boundaries. Conway (1995) traces the idea back to the 1950s; Teigland and Wasko (2003) claim the idea originated in the 1960s; Henderson and Clark (1990) draw on the literature from the 1970s. However, whatever its origin, the idea that innovation requires collaboration across boundaries is now well established (Fagerberg, Mowery, & Nelson, 2005).

The majority of the literature dealing with this area tends towards what Tsoukas (1996) describes as a taxonomic approach: seeking to discover global, or at least generic, solutions for effective knowledge sharing. These often attempt to formulate more or less complete descriptions of the different types of knowledge involved and to identify the specific conditions that facilitate their exchange. Such approaches are frequently based on macro-level, multi-firm

surveys and tend to view knowledge sharing as a continuous process (Bock, Zmud, Kim, & Lee, 2005; Chen & Huang, 2007; Hansen, 2002; Holsapple & Joshi, 2000). The spread of electronic communication (Coakes, Coakes, & Rosenberg, 2008) and notions such as the resource-based view of the firm (Grant, 1996; Wernerfelt, 1984) have also contributed to the popularity of this view.

Tsoukas (1996) and Tsoukas and Chia (2002) however claims that this approach is fundamentally flawed; quoting Boden (1994) he argues that the structures that shape how knowledge is shared are always and inevitably influenced by “*immediate circumstances and local agendas*” (Boden, 1994, p. 18). He argues instead for a view of knowledge that is dispersed with no single actor in a position to formulate rules or principles to determine what knowledge should be shared. This approach tends to view knowledge sharing as an episodic rather than a continuous process. Where categories and taxonomies exist, “*The stability of their meanings is precariously maintained*” (Tsoukas & Chia, 2002, p. 573): they are stable enough to be consistently deployed, but are always transient, local and open to negotiation.

Studies that examine collaboration and knowledge sharing from this perspective have received less attention in the literature and tend to be long-term ethnographic studies that place more emphasis on group dynamics and organizational politics. Blackler and McDonald (2000) provide one such example. Taking an action research approach, they describe the problems of building and

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